CONSUMER COMPLAINT TRENDS AND RESPONSE INTELLIGENCE REPORT

Analyst: Tessy Odiley

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ANALYSTLAB AFRICA

Consumer Complaints Intelligence Executive Report

Analysis Period: May 2017–August 2023

Executive Summary

This analysis evaluated six years of consumer complaint activity, complaint-processing intervals, product to issue complaint volumes and complaint submission channels. The main findings are summarized below:

- The CFPB received a total of 62,516 complaints relating to Bank of America over the six-year reporting period.
- The average complaint-forwarding interval was 1.2 days, indicating that the CFPB forwarded the complaints to the Bank of America within a short period after receipt.
- The Bank of America recorded a timely response rate of 96.06%, indicating a strong response time to consumer complaints.
- Among the product categories analyzed, checking and savings accounts generated the highest number of complaints, accounting for approximately 24,800 complaints during the reporting period.

Overall, the findings indicate that both the CFPB and Bank of America maintained relatively prompt complaint-processing and response practices. However, the high volume of complaints relating to checking and savings accounts highlights an area requiring further attention. In particular, improving customers' experiences with routine account transactions, including deposits and withdrawals, could help address recurring sources of consumer dissatisfaction and potentially reduce future complaint volumes.

Business Objectives

The Consumer Financial Protection Bureau (CFPB) requested analysis of its consumer complaints data relating to the Bank of America for the period from 2017 to 2023. The purpose of the analysis is to gain insights into consumer complaint patterns, identify recurring issues, and evaluate the company's complaint-handling practices.

Specifically, the analysis aims to:

- Identify trends and changes in consumer complaint volumes over the reporting period.
- Determine the most frequently reported consumer issues.
- Identify the financial products and services associated with the highest number of complaints.
- Examine recorded company responses and assess the timeliness of complaint handling.

- Evaluate complaint-processing timelines, including the time taken to forward complaints to the company.

The organization aims to understand:

- Complaint trends
- Frequently reported issues
- Financial products associated with complaints
- Recorded company responses
- Complaint-processing timelines

Key Findings

Executive Overview

Complaint volume generally increased throughout the reporting period, rising from approximately 5,400 complaints in 2017 to a peak of roughly 13,000 complaints in 2022. However, complaint volume declined to 9,131 in 2023. This decline should be interpreted cautiously, as the 2023 reporting period only covers data until August.

- The CFPB received a total of 62,516 complaints relating to Bank of America over the six-year reporting period. The average complaint-forwarding interval was 1.2 days, indicating that the CFPB forwarded the complaints to the Bank of America within a short period after receipt.
- The Bank of America recorded a timely response rate of 96.06%, indicating a strong and prompt response to consumer complaints. However, 1,494 complaints remained in progress at the end of the reporting period, suggesting that a portion of complaints had not yet received an outcome or the outcome had not yet been recorded.
- The total number of complaints the CFPB received for Bank of America decreased between 2022 and 2023. However, a 9.35% increase in complaint volume was recorded in 2023. Further investigation is required to determine the reason for this increase despite the overall decrease in volume.
- In terms of products, the checking or savings account product generated the highest number of complaints during the reporting period, accounting for approximately 24,800 complaints. In contrast, the student loan complaints represented the smallest proportion of complaints. This indicates that checking and savings account services were the primary source of consumer complaints.

- Year-over-year complaint volume increased steadily between 2020 and 2022, reaching a peak of 12,953 complaints in 2022. While the total number of complaints recorded in 2023 (9,131) was lower than the full-year total for 2022, complaint volume increased by 9.35% relative to the same period in the previous year (period ending in August, 2022; not the full year).

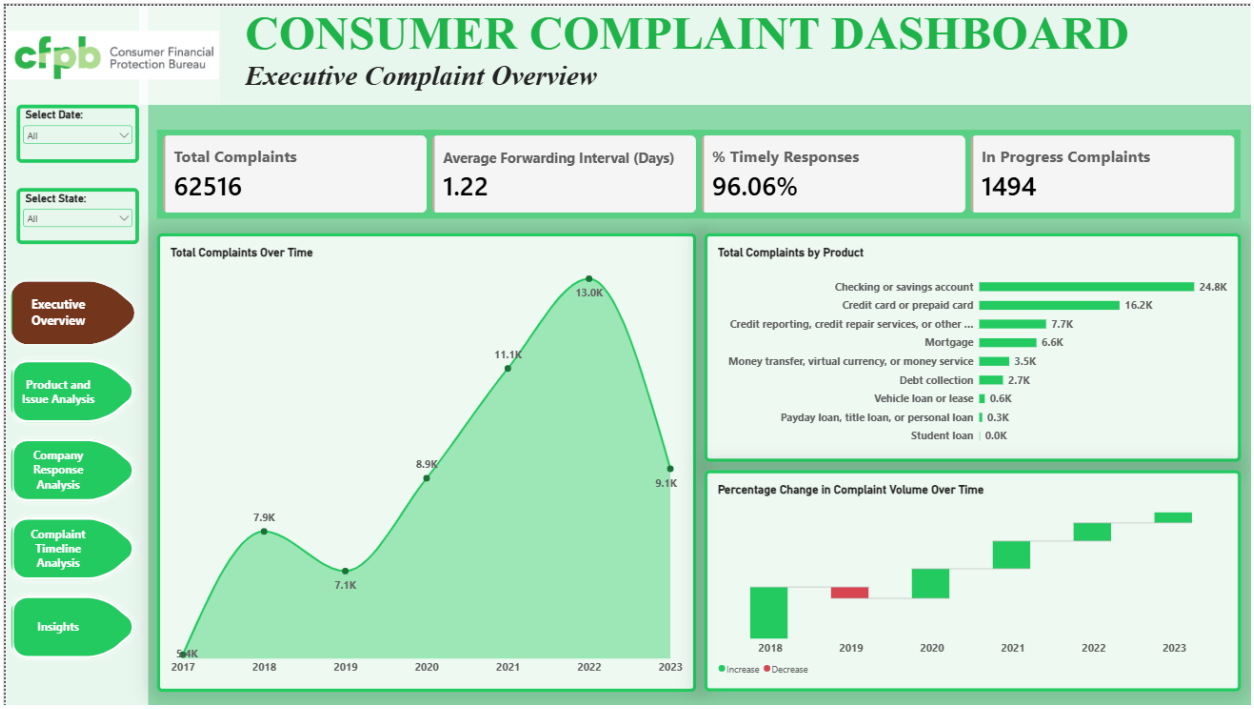


Figure 1: Executive Overview Dashboard.

Product and Issue Analysis

The product and issue analysis examined the products generating the highest number of complaints, the most common consumer issues, and the preferred complaint submission channel.

- **Product complaints:** During the reporting period, the checking account sub-product recorded approximately 20,700 complaints, with managing an account identified as the most common issue. This indicates that consumers find managing their checking accounts challenging.
- **Common sub-issues:** Deposits and withdrawals were the most frequently recorded sub-issues, suggesting that consumers experience difficulties with checking account transactions.
- **Complaint submission channels:** The web was the most frequently used complaint submission channel, accounting for approximately 8,000 complaints relating to account

management. Referrals ranked second with roughly 4,800 complaints. This indicates that consumers primarily rely on online submissions and referrals when reporting issues.

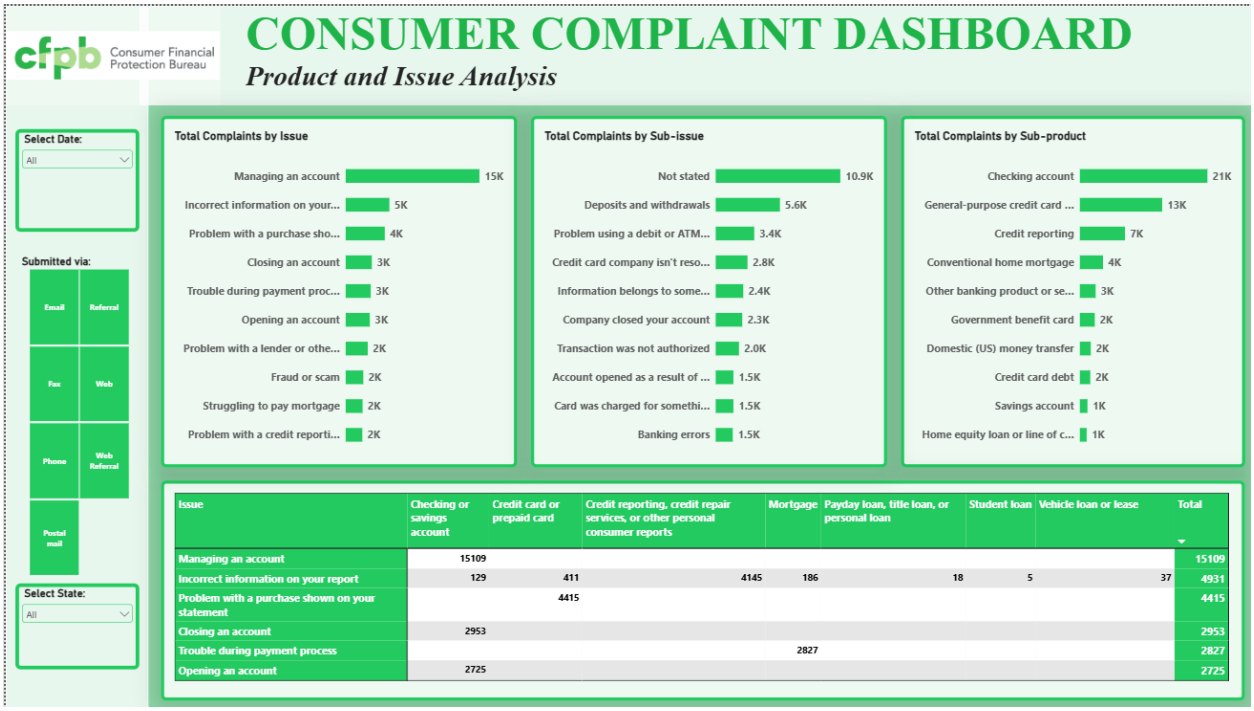


Figure 2: Product and Issues Analysis Dashboard.

Company Response Analysis

The company response analysis examined Bank of America's complaint-handling patterns over time.

- **Timely response rate:** The Bank of America recorded a timely response rate of 96.06%, suggesting that the company responds to complaints promptly.
- **Response trends over time:** Complaint response trends fluctuated over the reporting period, increasing from 5,385 in 2017 to a peak of 12,386 in 2022 before declining to approximately 7,100 in 2023.
- **Untimely responses:** Untimely response remained relatively low throughout the reporting period, although an increase was observed between 2021 and 2023, indicating delays were relatively uncommon compared to timely responses.
- **Response distribution:** This is supported by timely responses accounting for 93.77% of the company's total responses, while untimely responses only account for about 3.84%.
- **Complaints in progress:** At the time of reporting, 1494 complaints remained in progress. This suggests that these cases were either unresolved or the response status had not yet been recorded.
- **Public company responses:** The most frequently recorded public company response was *"Company has responded to the consumer and the CFPB and chooses not to provide a*

public response", accounting for 60,311 of the total complaint responses. This indicates that the company generally opted not to publish additional public explanations when responding to complaints.

- **Consumer response outcomes:** The most common recorded company response to consumers was *"Closed with explanation"*, accounting for 41,044 of complaint responses, indicating that the company frequently addressed complaints by providing explanations to the consumers before closing the case.

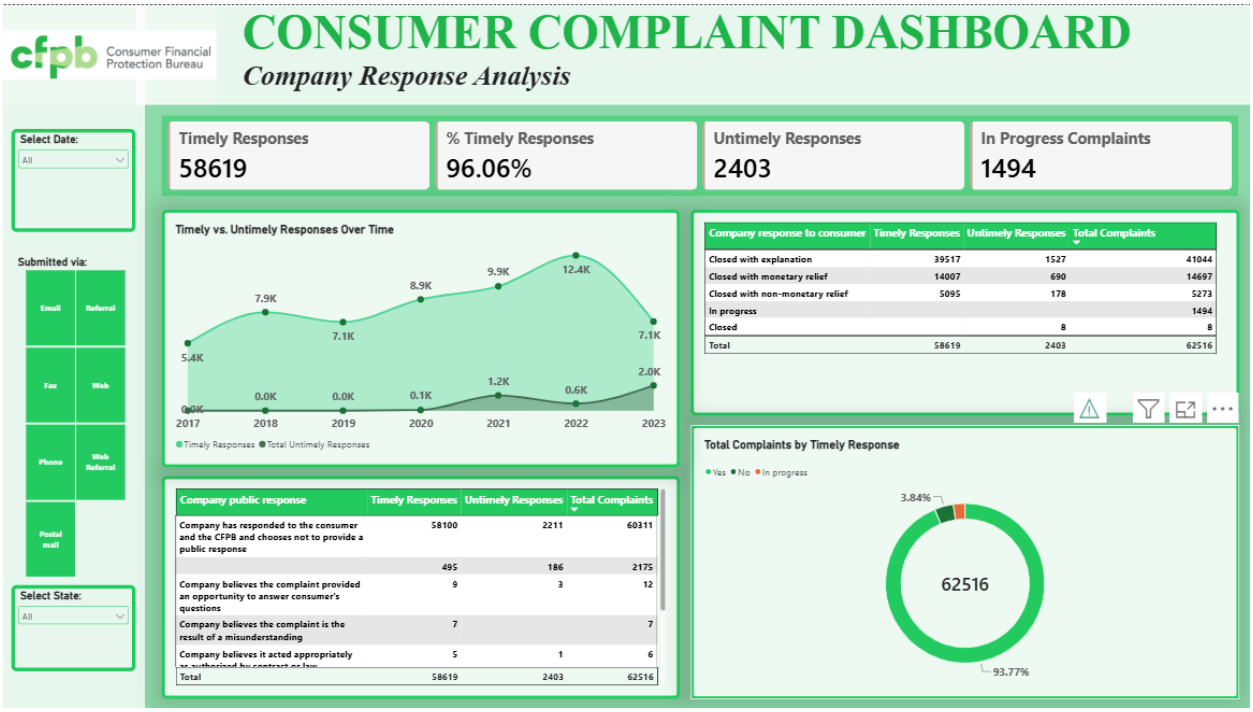


Figure 3: Company Response Analysis Dashboard.

Complaint Timeline Analysis

The complaint timeline analysis investigated the year-over-year changes in complaint volumes, average complaint forwarding intervals, and the proportion of total complaints attributed to various products over time.

- **Average forwarding interval:** The average forwarding interval for complaints was 1.22 days, while the median was 0 days. This suggests that most complaints were forwarded to Bank of America on the same day they were received by the CFPB.
- **Forwarding intervals by product:** Student loan complaints recorded the longest average forwarding interval of 2.1 days, indicating that these complaints generally took longer to reach the company compared to other product categories.
- **Overall complaint volume change:** Total complaint volume change was 28.15% over the reporting period. The CFPB recorded the largest increase in complaint volume in 2017, with an increase of approximately 5,400 complaints. Meanwhile, 2019 recorded a decline

of 797 complaints, indicating that complaint volumes fluctuated throughout the reporting period.

- **Complaint distribution by product:** Checking or savings account complaints consistently represented the largest proportion of complaints throughout the reporting period, accounting for 35.93% in 2021 and 44.74% in 2023.

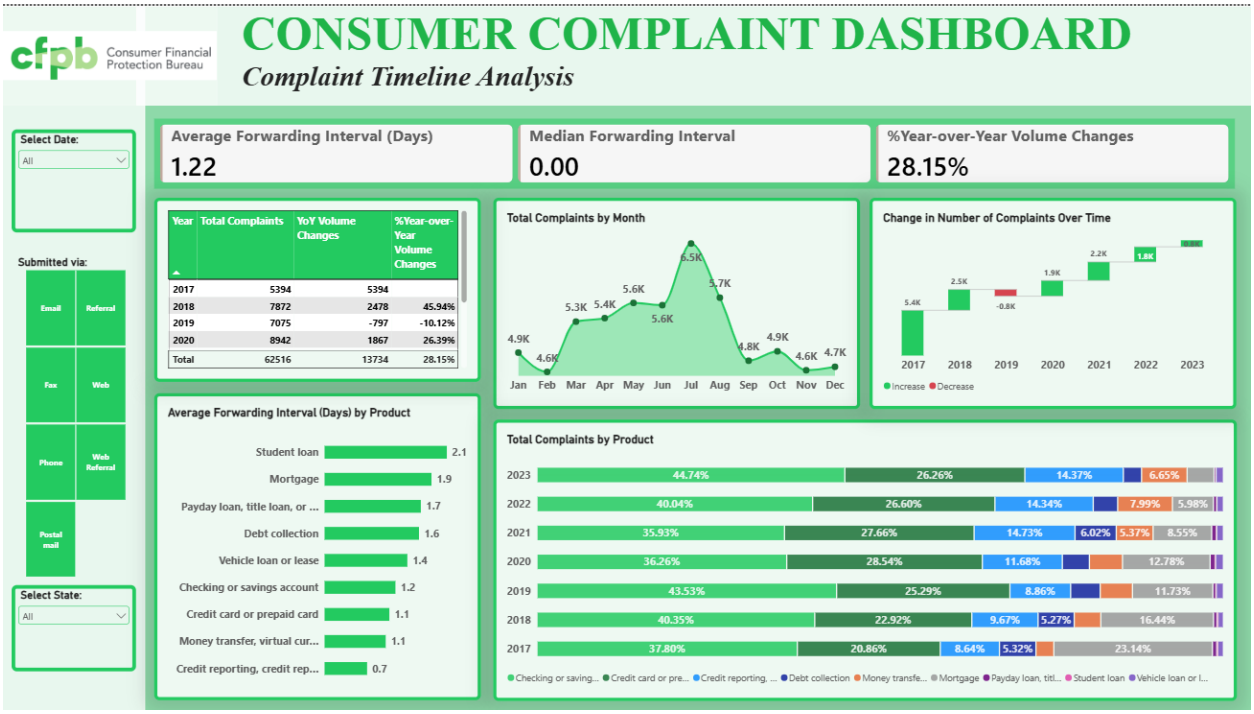


Figure 4: Complaint Timeline Analysis Dashboard.

Business Recommendations

Based on the findings generated by the analysis, the following recommendations are proposed to help Bank of America improve customer experiences, address recurring complaints, and strengthen its complaint-handling processes:

1. Improve Checking and Savings Account Services

Checking and savings accounts generated the highest number of complaints during the reporting period, accounting for approximately 24,800 complaints. Bank of America should prioritize making improvements to these products by investigating recurring customer complaints, identifying service gaps, and implementing measures to improve account management processes. The company should consider collecting customer information to conduct further investigation.

Target: Reduce complaints relating to checking and savings accounts by at least 15% over the next reporting cycle through improved account management services, customer support, and transaction processes.

2. Streamline Deposit and Withdrawal Processes

Deposits and withdrawals were among the most frequently reported customer issues. Bank of America should review its deposit and withdrawal procedures to identify potential causes of transaction difficulties, processing delays, and customer dissatisfaction. Improving transaction transparency and providing clearer guidance could help minimize recurring complaints.

Target: Reduce complaints relating to deposits and withdrawals by at least 20% over the next reporting cycle through improved transaction processing, error resolution, and customer communication.

3. Maintain and Improve Timely Complaint Responses

Bank of America recorded a timely response rate of 96.06%, indicating that the company responds to the majority of consumer complaints within a short period. The company should maintain this performance by monitoring response times, improving internal complaint-forwarding procedures, and ensuring that complaints are assigned to the appropriate departments.

Target: Maintain a timely complaint response rate of at least 96% over the next reporting cycle through improved complaint monitoring and response management.

4. Reduce Complaints Remaining in Progress

At the time of reporting, 1,494 complaints remained in progress, suggesting that these complaints were either unresolved or had not yet received updated response records. The CFPB should strengthen its complaint follow-up procedures by regularly reviewing outstanding cases, prioritizing older complaints, and ensuring that complaint statuses are updated accurately.

Target: Reduce complaints remaining in progress by at least 30% over the next reporting cycle through regular case reviews, improved follow-up procedures, and timely status updates.

5. Improve Digital Customer Support

The web was the most frequently used complaint submission channel, suggesting that customers rely heavily on online platforms when reporting issues. The CFPB should improve its digital customer support services by enhancing website navigation, providing accessible self-service resources, and offering clearer guidance on common account-related problems through links to the relevant Bank of America web pages.

Target: Reduce web-submitted complaints relating to account management by at least 15% over the next reporting cycle through improved providing information links to where customers can find digital banking support, online resources, and customer guidance from Bank of America.

6. Strengthen Complaint Monitoring and Reporting

The analysis identified fluctuations in complaint volumes over the reporting period, highlighting the importance of continuous monitoring. The CFPB and Bank of America should establish regular complaint-monitoring procedures to identify emerging customer concerns, assess response performance, and evaluate the effectiveness of implemented improvements.

Target: Implement monthly complaint-monitoring reports and quarterly performance reviews to track complaint volumes, recurring issues, response timeliness, and complaint resolution outcomes.

The results from implementing these recommendations should be reviewed on a bi-annual basis, and resolutions should be communicated with both CFPB and Bank of America.

Assumptions

The analysis was conducted using the following assumptions:

- The CFPB consumer complaint dataset accurately reflects complaints submitted by consumers against Bank of America during the reporting period.
- Complaints recorded against Bank of America were correctly classified according to the relevant financial product, issue, sub-issue, submission channel and company response.
- The dates recorded in the dataset accurately represent the complaint submission and forwarding timelines.
- Each complaint represents a separate consumer complaint record, although multiple complaints may relate to similar experiences or underlying issues.
- The available data provides a reasonable basis for identifying complaint trends and evaluating the bank's recorded responses during the reporting period.

Limitations

The analysis has several limitations that should be considered when interpreting the findings:

- **Data completeness:** The analysis relies on information recorded in the CFPB dataset. Missing, incomplete or unrecorded information may affect the accuracy of certain findings.
- **Reporting period:** The analysis covers May 2017 to August 2023 and therefore does not reflect complaint activity outside this period or more recent developments.
- **Complaint representation:** The number of complaints does not necessarily represent the total number of consumers experiencing problems with Bank of America, as not all dissatisfied consumers submit complaints to the CFPB.
- **Scope of information:** The dataset provides information about reported complaints and recorded company responses but does not necessarily establish the underlying cause of every complaint or whether the consumer’s issue was satisfactorily resolved. Therefore, inferences about customer satisfaction cannot be generated.
- **Response measurements:** Response timeliness and recorded response status should not be interpreted as direct measures of customer satisfaction or service quality.

- **Variations in complaint volume:** Changes in complaint numbers may be influenced by factors beyond the bank's performance, including changes in customer activity, reporting behavior and external economic conditions.

Risks

The findings highlight several potential risks for Bank of America:

- **Customer dissatisfaction:** The high volume of complaints relating to checking and savings accounts may indicate recurring customer difficulties with account management and daily banking transactions.
- **Transaction-related issues:** The frequency of complaints involving deposits and withdrawals presents a risk of continued customer dissatisfaction if transaction-related problems are not addressed effectively.
- **Complaint resolution delays:** The 1,494 complaints recorded as remaining in progress may indicate potential delays in complaint resolution or incomplete and inconsistent recording of final complaint statuses.
- **Reputational risk:** A sustained volume of consumer complaints may negatively affect public confidence in the bank if recurring issues are not adequately addressed.

Conclusions

The analysis examined 62,516 consumer complaints relating to Bank of America submitted to the CFPB between May 2017 and August 2023. It evaluated complaint trends, processing timelines, financial products and issues associated with complaints, submission channels and recorded company responses.

The findings indicate that checking and savings accounts generated the highest number of complaints, with approximately 24,800 complaints recorded. Account management was a frequently reported issue, while deposits and withdrawals were the most common recorded sub-issues. The web was also the most frequently used complaint submission channel, highlighting the importance of effective digital banking services and online customer support.

Overall, the findings suggest that complaint forwarding and company response timeliness were generally strong. However, the volume and nature of complaints relating to checking and savings accounts highlight areas where improvements may be necessary. Bank of America should prioritize account management and deposit and withdrawal processes. The CFPB should prioritize improving digital customer support and complaint follow-up. Implementing measurable improvement targets and regularly monitoring complaint data could help the bank address recurring consumer concerns, and help the CFPB improve complaint-handling practices.